

a fifteen-year-old dog way over the \$30,000 range. That's assuming no surprise vet visits for broken doggie bones, dental work, swallowed socks, or hip dysplasia, let alone continuing costs to treat diabetes or thyroid conditions. In fact, consider vet insurance if you're not budgeting for the doggie emergency room.

If these costs don't deter you and you still want to make room for Fido or Fluffy, then do your research and stick to a manageable breed, one that isn't prone to pricey health issues. For my money, mutts and mixed-breed animals are always the healthier, heartier choice. And stay away from pet stores and breeders. Adopt your animal from a reputable shelter where it is sure to be spayed or neutered and arrive with all its shots. Or better yet, volunteer as a dog walker at your local Humane Society. Or foster an animal—you'd be doing a community service, but the best part? Food and medicine are free to you. All you need to do is take care of the animal until it's adopted, because you're not going to fall in love with it and completely defeat the purpose of this exercise. Right? Plus, you'll get some valuable (and free) dog-walking training, which you can monetize to make some extra money on the side. This is a great way for cash-strapped retirees to pick up some extra cash and get a little exercise to boot.

If all else fails, get a fish. They're easy to feed. Easy to dispose of when they die. No vet bills. In fact, get two.

Money Mistake: The War on Aging Is Expensive

THE FIX: CHOOSE YOUR WALLET OVER YOUR FACE

No generation has wanted to stay forever young more than the baby boomers. Maybe because unlike young people today, we lived in flush times. When we cast our eyes backward, the times were indeed better. At least economically speaking. And just when we finally have pantloads of cash, we look in the mirror and realize we're middle-aged.

You've probably heard me say this on TV: Antiaging services have the best profit margins on the planet, and they're the worst wastes of